

Lecture Notes: Select Topics in Living Systems

Based on lectures by **Dr. Ram Adar** in 2025–26
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These notes were typed during the 2026 winter semester *Select Topics in Living Systems* course taught by **Dr. Ram Adar** at the Technion.

The lectures were given in Hebrew and were live-translated by me to English. The document is provided as is and likely contains many errors.

If you find any mistakes or typos please let me know at danielbreger@campus.technion.ac.il.

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Wed, October 29, 2025

1 Phase Transitions in Equilibrium

1.1 Motivation

Phase is a distinct state of matter which can be described by an “order parameter”. We’ll focus on isotropic polar phase transition. In this case the order parameter is the polarization $\mathbf{p} = \langle \hat{n} \rangle$ where $\hat{n}$ is the unit vector of the particles’ direction.

Phase transition

In certain areas of physics we see systems which aren’t ordered at high temperatures but become ordered at low temperatures. Why? A competition between energy and entropy (Free energy being $F = U - TS$). The temperature at which order emerges is called the critical temperature, marked T_C and the change in the system is called a phase transition.

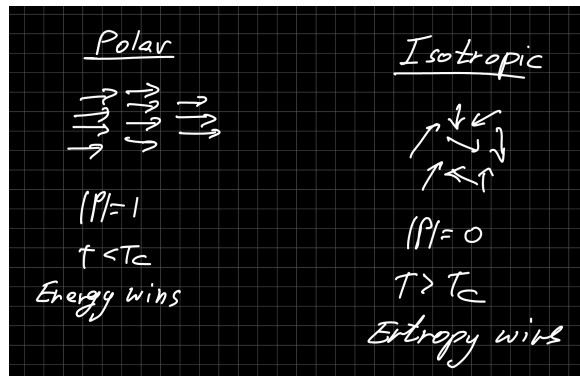


Figure 1.1: Polar and Isotropic ordering of matter.

1.2 Physical Description

We’ll assume free energy of the following form:

$$F(T, N, \psi) = F_0(T, N) + F_\psi(T, N, \psi) \quad (1.1)$$

where ψ is the order parameter. ψ is not a conserved quantity but rather a degree of freedom of the system (in contrast to the number of particles, for example). Therefore under equilibrium we find

$$F_{eq}(T, N, \psi) = F_0(T, N) + F_\psi(T, N, \psi_{eq}) \quad (1.2)$$

and the equilibrium value is determined by

$$\left. \frac{\partial F_\psi}{\partial \psi} \right|_{\psi=\psi_{eq}} = 0 \quad (1.3)$$

and the following is true:

$$\psi_{eq}(T > T_C) = 0 \quad (1.4)$$

$$\psi_{eq}(T < T_C) \neq 0 \quad (1.5)$$

We’ll focus on phase transition of 2nd order, for which the order parameter changes continuously, thus $\psi_{eq}(T = T_C) = 0$. Otherwise the phase transition is of first order.

1.3 Landau Theory of Phase Transitions

The theory was developed by Lev Landau, for which he earned the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1962. It states that close to the critical temperature T_C the physics of phase transitions is universal. For a phase transition of 2nd order, we will write F_ψ in a phenomenological form as a Taylor series expansion:

$$F_\psi = \frac{a}{2}\psi^2 + \frac{b}{4}\psi^4 \quad (1.6)$$

The terms being of even powers because we don't care about directions. The quadratic term's coefficient is of the form

$$a = a_0 \cdot \frac{T - T_C}{T_C} \quad (1.7)$$

Where $a_0 > 0$. This quantifies the competition between energy (which wins at $T < T_C$) and entropy (which wins at $T > T_C$). The parameter $b > 0$ ensures stability: ψ_{eq} receives finite values and does not approach infinity. Because of a 's sign, we find $\psi_{eq} \neq 0$ for $T < T_C$. Explicitly:

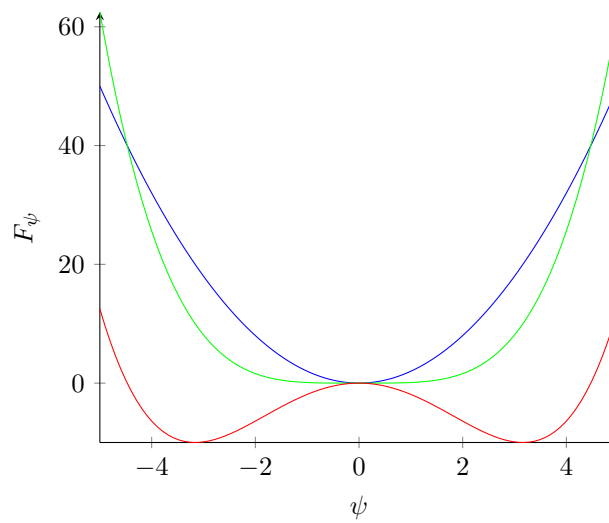


Figure 1.2: The graphs for the functions $2x^2$ (blue), $0.1x^4$ (green) and $0.1x^4 - 2x^2$ (red).

$$0 = \left. \frac{\partial F}{\partial \psi} \right|_{\psi=\psi_{eq}} = a\psi_{eq} + b\psi_{eq}^3 = b\psi_{eq} \left(\psi_{eq}^2 + \frac{a}{b} \right) \quad (1.8)$$

therefore

$$\psi_{eq} = 0, \pm \sqrt{\frac{a_0}{b} \cdot \frac{T - T_C}{T_C}} \quad (1.9)$$

There is no distinction between the positive and negative sign. Either can be chosen arbitrarily (spontaneous symmetry break). There will be a preference given an external field which will add an element of the form $-h\psi$ to the free energy.

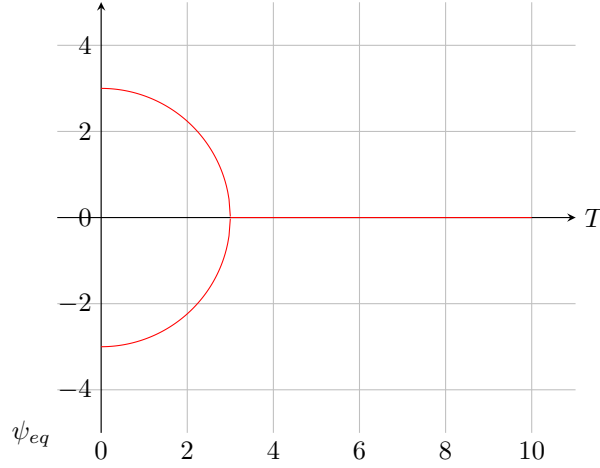


Figure 1.3: The possible solutions from equation 1.9.

Where the parameter a comes from

We'll assume a simple model of polarisation with energy

$$U = - \sum_{i,j \text{ neighbors}} u n_{\alpha}^i n_{\alpha}^j, \quad u > 0 \quad (1.10)$$

The energy is lower when i,j point in the same direction. Using mean field approximation the internal energy is

$$U = \frac{u}{2} \sum_{i,j} \langle n_{\alpha}^i \rangle \cdot \langle n_{\alpha}^j \rangle = -\frac{u}{2} N Z p_{\alpha}^2 \quad (1.11)$$

where $p_{\alpha} = \langle n_{\alpha} \rangle$, N is the number of particles, and Z the number of close neighbors. As for the entropy, we can find from a Taylor expansion

$$S = S(p=0) - \alpha N p^2 \quad (1.12)$$

and summing it up we find

$$F = U - TS = N \left(\alpha T - \frac{u}{2} Z \right) p^2 = a_0 \cdot \frac{T - T_C}{T_C} p^2 \quad (1.13)$$

where

$$T_C = \frac{uZ}{2\alpha} \quad a_0 = \alpha N T_C \quad (1.14)$$

If instead of the vector n_{α} there is spin ($\pm$) then we find a similar result in the mean field framework. This model is called the Ising model, one of the most basic and useful models in statistical mechanics.

A dynamical description of the phase transition

We described the phase transition from the free energy but we can also describe it from dynamics. For a non-conserved order parameter we can write the dynamics as follows:

$$\dot{\psi} = -\Gamma_{\psi} \frac{\partial F}{\partial \psi}, \quad \Gamma_{\psi} > 0 \quad (1.15)$$

the idea being that the dynamics guarantee that the free energy only gets smaller (the total entropy grows). We can see this using the chain rule:

$$\dot{F} = \frac{\partial F}{\partial \psi} \dot{\psi} = -\Gamma_{\psi} \left(\frac{\partial F}{\partial \psi} \right)^2 < 0 \quad (1.16)$$

this dynamics is called Model A (and often appears with a “noise” parameter). We’ll insert F and find:

$$\dot{p} = -\Gamma_p(ap + bp^3) \quad (1.17)$$

the fixed points are $\frac{\partial F}{\partial p} = 0$, the extremums of the free energy. The stability of the solution is determined in phase space. in the language of dynamical systems, a phase transition is called a

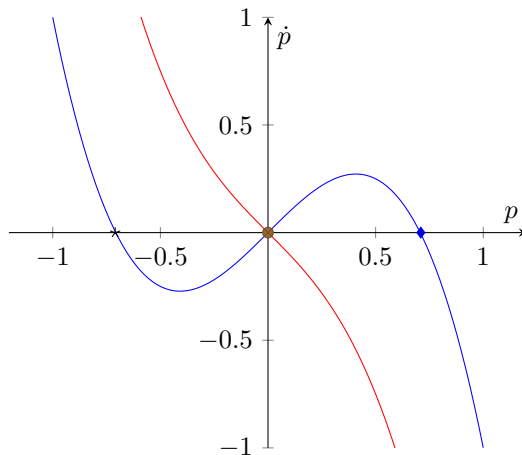


Figure 1.4: The graphs of $f(x) = x - 2x^3$ (blue) and $g(x) = -x - 2x^3$ (red). The positive and negative points marked on the x axis are stable points of equilibrium for $f(x)$. The point marked at $(0,0)$ is a stable point for $g(x)$ but an unstable one for $f(x)$

bifurcation. This approach is useful for out of equilibrium systems, for which we can’t write down a free energy. Later on in the course, we’ll come across dynamical equations of a similar form. In general dynamical systems, when a function F whose derivative is strictly non-positive with a finite minimum exists (like free energy), then it’s called a Lyapunov function.

1.4 Spatial Dependence: The Ginsburg-Landau Theory

We saw that the direction of $\mathbf{p}$ is arbitrary, in practice different areas of the system will initially develop order in different directions. For simplicity, we’ll assume $\mathbf{p} = p\hat{y}$ where p can be either positive or negative. We’ll look at the case where $\mathbf{p}$ points down at $x \rightarrow -\infty$ and up at $x \rightarrow \infty$.

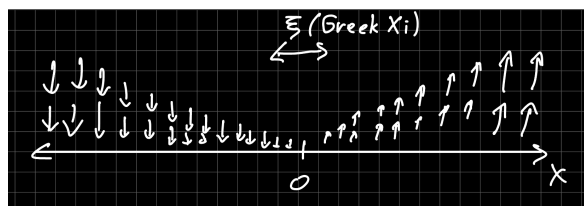


Figure 1.5: A smooth phase transition with Domain Wall ξ .

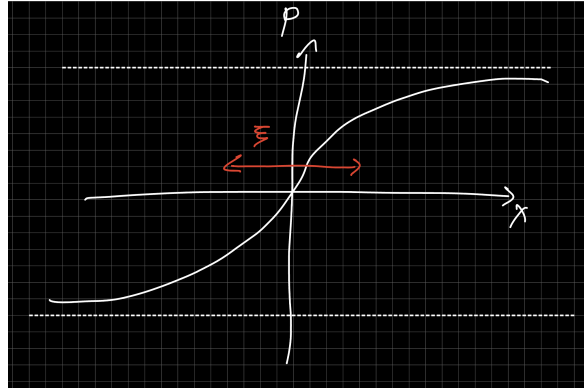


Figure 1.6: A smooth phase transition with Domain Wall ξ .

We'll find a finite range around 0 of width χ in which $|\mathbf{p}| \neq p_{eq}$. This region is called the Domain Wall. To quantify the cost to change $\mathbf{p}$ in space we'll write the density of free energy per length unit:

$$F[p] = \int dx f = \int dx \left(\frac{a}{2} p^2 + \frac{b}{4} p^4 + \frac{k}{2} p'^2 \right) \quad (1.18)$$

where $k > 0$. The last element quantifies the cost to change p . In higher dimensions we'll have $(\nabla p)^2$. Why is it like this? The cost comes from the gradient, and given there is no preferred direction, a positive and negative change should cost the same.

Lecture 2.

Wed, November 5, 2025

The profile $p(x)$ is at the point where the functional derivative (with deltas) of F with respect to p is 0, i.e

$$0 = \frac{\partial f}{\partial p} - \left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial p'} \right)' ; F = \int dx f \quad (2.1)$$

If we apply this to our specific functional we find

$$0 = \frac{\delta F}{\delta p} = ap + bp^3 - kp'' \quad (2.2)$$

which if we simplify it we find

$$\frac{k}{a} p'' = p + \frac{b}{a} p^3 \quad (2.3)$$

if we focus on the case where $a < 0$ and $p_{eq}^2 = \frac{L}{a}$ then

$$-\frac{k}{|a|} p'' = p \left(1 - \frac{p^2}{p_{eq}^2} \right) \quad (2.4)$$

which using dimensional analysis we found a length scale that goes with $\sqrt{\frac{k}{|a|}}$. Looking back at figure 1.6 we guess a solution of the form

$$p_0(x) = p_{eq} \tanh \frac{x}{\xi} \quad (2.5)$$

and use the following identity

$$\tanh' x = \frac{1}{\cosh^2 x} = 1 - \tanh^2 x \quad (2.6)$$

we find

$$p'' = \frac{p_{eq}}{\xi} \left(1 - \tanh^2 \frac{x}{\xi} \right)' \quad (2.7)$$

$$= -2 \frac{p_{eq}}{\xi^2} \tanh \frac{x}{\xi} \left(1 - \tanh^2 \frac{x}{\xi} \right) \quad (2.8)$$

$$= -\frac{2}{\xi^2} p_0 \left(1 - \frac{p_0^2}{p_{eq}^2} \right) \quad (2.9)$$

and from this we conclude

$$\frac{2}{\xi^2} \frac{k}{|a|} = 1 \rightarrow \xi = \sqrt{\frac{2k}{|a|}} \quad (2.10)$$

in particular, near the phase transition ($a \approx 0$), ξ diverges. Additionally, the excess free energy in the ξ width layer in comparison to the energy in phases at $\pm p_{eq}$ is called the interfacial tension (γ). It can be shown (in homework) that

$$\gamma = \int k p_0'^2 dx = \sqrt{\frac{-8ka^3}{9b^2}} \quad (2.11)$$

1.5 The Mermin-Wagner (-Hohenberg) Theorem

So far we dealt with spatial change of a binary order parameter p , like spin, such that $\mathbf{p} = p\hat{y}$ but in a more general case $\mathbf{p} = p(\cos \theta, \sin \theta)$ and θ can change continuously. We'll notice that

$$F_p = \frac{a}{2}|\mathbf{p}|^2 + \frac{b}{4}|\mathbf{p}|^4 \quad (2.12)$$

is invariant under a change of θ . This is a continuous symmetry and θ is called the Goldstone/soft mode.

The Theorem Itself

A system under equilibrium at temperature $T > 0$ of dimension $d \leq 2$ will NOT develop a long range order which breaks a continuous symmetry.

Explanation

Let's look at how the free energy is dependent on θ . There is no homogeneous contribution but rather only from derivatives. As before, we'll write

$$F = \frac{k}{2} \int d\mathbf{r} (\nabla \theta)^2 \quad (2.13)$$

Looking at a configuration such as

How much free energy does it cost to create a continuous change in θ in a system of dimension d with characteristic length L ? From dimensional considerations $\nabla^2 \sim L^{-2}$ and $\int d\mathbf{r} \sim L^d$ therefore $F \sim L^{d-2}$. For a large L and $d \leq 2$ the cost is low. Therefore change in θ will happen in a spontaneous manner from thermal fluctuations at $T > 0$.

A couple notes

1. In this course we will focus on *active systems out of equilibrium*. The theorem is violated and we can achieve long range order in 2D. This was the first result in active matter which created significant interest in the field.
2. Even in equilibrium a phase transition under the theorem's conditions is possible ($d = 2, T > 0$). In this case the order is not exactly long-range and is characterized by topological defects of the order parameter (we'll deal with defects later in the course). Sometimes such a transition is viewed as a KT transition (Kosterlitz-Thouless, 2016 Nobel prize in Physics)

2 Matter Out of Thermal Equilibrium

2.1 Types of Systems Out of Thermal Equilibrium

In general two main types of systems out of thermal equilibrium exist:

Non-Equilibrium Steady State In this case an outside energy source is injecting energy into the system, mostly through the system's edge, which dissipates. Examples:

1. Shear flow: Energy flows through the externally driven surfaces and dissipates through viscosity.
2. Electric circuits: A source is driving an electric current through the circuit, which dissipates at the resistor.

Near-Equilibrium Systems The system was previously in thermal equilibrium, which it left due to a controlled change in a thermodynamical parameter (T,P) or of an external potential. We can characterize the dynamics of the system arriving at the new equilibrium (relaxation). Examples:

1. Moving an optical trap: a colloid is captive in an optical trap which is suddenly moved. How does the colloid's position change over time?
2. Polymers stretching: a polymer is held on both ends by a force f . The force is suddenly changed. How will the edge-to-edge length of the polymer change?

In this course we will focus on active matter in which the energy is consumed locally by the system's elements. We will mostly focus on the case of a steady state. In general, given a system with measurable dynamics (such as a biological system), we will want to know whether it is in thermal equilibrium or not.

2.2 Macroscopic Description of Movement

In thermal equilibrium a closed system can only carry out a combination of uniform linear motion and rigid body rotation. Therefore, movement out of equilibrium will mostly be characterized by:

Wet Active Matter A closed system with non-uniform motion, such as a liquid with shearing. A relevant active system example for this case is active particles in a liquid.

Dry Active Matter An open system with uniform or non-uniform motion. A relevant active system example for this case is active particles on a surface.

Intuition

A system in which heat is created is out of equilibrium, since its entropy grows. In the first example heat is created due to viscosity and in the second due to friction. In an active system heat can be created from the active mechanism itself too (e.g a chemical reaction).

2.3 Proof of the statement in 2.2

We'll section a body into small but macroscopic parts with mass, energy, and momentum m_i , E_i , p_i respectively. The entropy results from the internal energy, and not from the kinetic energy of the center of mass.

$$S = \sum_i S_i(E_i - \frac{p_i^2}{2m_i}) \quad (2.14)$$

In a closed system the angular and linear momenta are conserved:

$$\sum_i \mathbf{p}_i = \text{const.} \quad \sum_i \mathbf{r}_i \times \mathbf{p}_i = \text{const.} \quad (2.15)$$

In thermal equilibrium the entropy is maximized while conforming to the constraints.

$$0 = \frac{\partial}{\partial \mathbf{p}_i} \sum_j \left[S_j \left(E_j - \frac{p_j^2}{2m_j} \right) + \mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{p}_j + \mathbf{b} \cdot (\mathbf{r}_i \times \mathbf{p}_j) \right] \quad (2.16)$$

$$= -\frac{1}{T} \frac{\mathbf{p}_i}{m_i} + \mathbf{a} + \mathbf{b} \times \mathbf{r}_i \quad (2.17)$$

$$\rightarrow \mathbf{v}_i = \mathbf{u} + \mathbf{\Omega} \times \mathbf{r}_i \quad (2.18)$$

where

$$\mathbf{u} = T \cdot \mathbf{a} \qquad \mathbf{\Omega} = T \cdot \mathbf{b} \quad (2.19)$$

2.4 Detailed Balance & Time Reversal Symmetry

Detailed Balance

Assume a system with microstates $\{s\}$ and a probability function P_s which changes with time. Its dynamics are given by a Master Equation:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} P_s = \sum_{s'} (P_{s'} W_{s' \rightarrow s} - P_s W_{s \rightarrow s'}) \quad (2.20)$$

where $W_{s \rightarrow s'}$ is the transition rate between s and s' . At equilibrium a detailed balance exists, each element in the sum cancels out:

$$P_{s'} W_{s' \rightarrow s} = P_s W_{s \rightarrow s'} \quad (2.21)$$

Sometimes this is instead written as

$$\frac{P_s}{P_{s'}} = \frac{W_{s' \rightarrow s}}{W_{s \rightarrow s'}} \quad (2.22)$$

Wed, November 19, 2025

Example: Movement on a 1D lattice

Let's look at a 1-dimensional lattice with N sites such that the probability to be at each site is $1/N$. For a random walk (such as diffusion)

$$W_{i,i+1} = W_{i+1,i} \quad (3.1)$$

since the probability of moving in either direction is equal. This results in a detailed balance. Next let's assume an active particle with a "positive spin" (i.e it moves to the right), therefore

$$W_{i,i+1} > W_{i+1,i} \quad (3.2)$$

and as a result there is no detailed balance. It is possible to connect the rate $W_{i,i+1}$ compared to $W_{i+1,i}$ to the difference between a step forward or backwards in time. Therefore systems with time reversal symmetry also are in detailed balance.

Time Reversal Symmetry

Systems in Equilibrium are symmetric to time reversal. If we watch a video of their dynamics and run it backwards, we won't feel a difference. This isn't necessarily true for active particles (like swimming fish). We'll assume a system with a hamiltonian which is a function of the momenta p^N (e.g $H = \sum_i \frac{p_i^2}{2m} + U(\mathbf{r})$) and that there is no magnetic field or global rotation which will add linear elements to the momenta. The dynamics of this system are given by Hamilton's equations:

$$\frac{dr_k}{dt} = \frac{\partial H}{\partial p_k} \quad \frac{dp_k}{dt} = -\frac{\partial H}{\partial r_k} \quad (3.3)$$

Since H is an even function w.r.t p , $\frac{\partial H}{\partial p_k}$ is odd. Looking at

$$t = -\bar{t} \quad r_k = \bar{r}_k \quad p_k = -\bar{p}_k \quad (3.4)$$

we see that we'll get the same equations for $\bar{t}, \bar{r}_k, \bar{p}_k$. What does this mean? Assume we start moving in phase space at the point (r^N, p^N) . After any time period τ we'll reach the point $(r^{N'}, p^{N'})$. Next we'll start at the point $(r^{N'}, p^{N'})$, and after another time period τ we'll reach (r^N, p^N) . This is called time reversal symmetry. When there is no time reversal symmetry the system is out of equilibrium. For example, looking at an active particle in 2D with velocity

$$\frac{d\mathbf{r}_k}{dt} = v(\cos \theta_k, \sin \theta_k) \quad (3.5)$$

where θ is a random variable distributed between 0 and 2π . When we reverse time, the left side of the equation will inverse but the right side won't.

2.5 The Fluctuation Dissipation Theorem

In thermal equilibrium or near it there is a fundamental connection between thermal fluctuations and the reaction to external forces, and it's called the FDT (Fluctuation-Dissipation Theorem). It has many versions and many implications and it is one of the most important and useful results in statistical mechanics. The connection between spontaneous fluctuations and reactions to external disturbances was identified by Lars Onsager, and he received the 1968 Nobel prize in chemistry for it (Onsager's regression hypothesis)

Static Version (In equilibrium)

We'll assume a system with hamiltonian H_0 and we'll apply an external force f with a tied field x such that $H = H_0 - fx$. In equilibrium:

$$\langle x \rangle = \frac{\sum_i x_i e^{-\beta(H_0 - fx_i)}}{e^{-\beta(H_0 - fx_i)}} \quad (3.6)$$

therefore

$$\frac{\partial \langle x \rangle}{\partial \beta f} = \frac{\sum_i x_i^2 e^{-\beta H}}{\sum_i e^{-\beta H}} - \langle x \rangle \frac{\sum_i e^{-\beta H} x_i}{\sum_i e^{-\beta H_i}} \quad (3.7)$$

noticing the first element is the average of x_i squared we get

$$k_B T \frac{\partial \langle x \rangle}{\partial f} = \langle x^2 \rangle - \langle x \rangle^2 \quad (3.8)$$

Near Equilibrium

We'll assume a system near equilibrium such that the deviation from equilibrium is linear in the field which takes it out of equilibrium. We'll assume a quantity x with a time independent equilibrium average $\langle x \rangle$. Still, x performs thermal fluctuations such that $\delta x(t) = x(t) - \langle x \rangle$ while $\langle \delta x \rangle = 0$. We can learn information about the system from its time correlation function:

$$C(t, t') = \langle \delta x(t) \delta x(t') \rangle = [\text{in equilibrium}] = C(t - t') \quad (3.9)$$

therefore we can write

$$C(t) = \langle \delta x(0) \delta x(t) \rangle = \langle x(0)x(t) \rangle - \langle x \rangle^2 \quad (3.10)$$

which is a generalization of the variance to include time dependence. The averages used above are for different starting conditions

$$C(t) = \int dr^N dp^N \delta x(0) \delta x(t) g(r^N, p^N) \quad (3.11)$$

in thermal equilibrium g is defined by the Boltzmann distribution. Looking at a system in which a field f is acting starting at $t' \rightarrow -\infty$ such that at $t = 0$ the system is in thermal equilibrium with $H = H_0 - fx$. We'll assume that at time $t = 0$ the field is switched off. We find that

$$k_B T \frac{\bar{x}(t) - \langle x \rangle}{f} = \langle x(t)x(0) \rangle - \langle x \rangle^2 \quad (3.12)$$

where $\bar{x}(t)$ is the average given by the starting conditions out of equilibrium. A full development can be found in the appendixes.

In Terms of Reaction Function

In general

$$\delta\bar{x}(t) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} dt' \chi(t, t') f(t') \quad (3.13)$$

where χ is a reaction function. χ is determined by the properties of the system in equilibrium (taking into consideration corrections of order f to δx) therefore $\chi(t, t') = \chi(t - t')$, there is no meaning to absolute time but only for the time since the disturbance. In addition, the disturbance only affects the future (causality). We'll define

$$f(t) = \begin{cases} f & t < 0 \\ 0 & t \geq 0 \end{cases} \quad (3.14)$$

and we found that

$$\langle \delta x(0) \delta x(t) \rangle = \frac{k_B T}{f} \overline{\delta x} = \frac{k_B T}{f} \int_{-\infty}^0 dt' \chi(t - t') f \quad (3.15)$$

$$= k_B T \int_t^{\infty} dt'' \chi(t'') \quad (3.16)$$

differentiating we find

$$\frac{dC}{dt} = -k_B T \chi(t), \quad t \geq 0 \quad (3.17)$$

Which is a more popular formulation of the same. We'll look at yet another alternative formulation. In an experiment we can examine whether FDT happens (if the system is near thermal equilibrium) by looking at the spectrum of the response and correlation functions.

$$\hat{C}(\omega) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} dt C(t) e^{i\omega t} \quad \hat{\chi}(\omega) = \int_0^{\infty} dt \chi(t) e^{i\omega t} = \chi'(\omega) + i\chi''(\omega) \quad (3.18)$$

and we find

$$\hat{C}(\omega) = \frac{2k_B T}{\omega} \hat{\chi}''(\omega) \quad (3.19)$$

Why is $\hat{\chi}''$ dissipation? For a periodic force $f = f_0 \cos(\omega t)$ we find

$$\chi(t) = \text{Re}[\chi(\omega) f(\omega) e^{-i\omega t}] \quad (3.20)$$

$$= \hat{\chi}'(\omega) f_0 \cos \omega t + \hat{\chi}''(\omega) f_0 \sin \omega t \quad (3.21)$$

$$\rightarrow \dot{x}(t) = -f_0 \hat{\chi}'(\omega) \cdot \omega \sin \omega t + f_0 \hat{\chi}''(\omega) \cdot \omega \cos \omega t \quad (3.22)$$

then the average dissipation in a period T is

$$\frac{1}{T} \int_0^T dt f(x) \dot{x}(t) = \frac{1}{2} f_0^2 \omega \hat{\chi}''(\omega) \quad (3.23)$$

Lecture 4.

Wed, November 26th, 2025

2.6 Example: Brownian Motion & The Einstein Relation

Assume a system of particles, specifically colloids (large brownian particle) which is moved with an external force F in 1 dimension. The particle's motion is given by

$$\dot{x} = \mu F + v_B \quad (4.1)$$

where μ is the colloid's mobility, v_B is the noise element of brownian motion. This noise element has the following properties

$$\langle v_B(t) \rangle = 0 \quad \langle v_B(t)v_B(t') \rangle = 2D\delta(t-t') \quad (4.2)$$

where D is the diffusion parameter. Without a force we will find

$$\langle x(t) \rangle = \int_0^t dt' \langle v_B(t') \rangle = 0 \quad (4.3)$$

as the expectation value of a sum is the sum of the expectation values. Additionally,

$$\langle x^2 \rangle = \left\langle \int_0^t dt' v_B(t') \int_0^t dt'' v_B(t'') \right\rangle \quad (4.4)$$

$$= \int_0^t dt' 2D \int_0^t dt'' \delta(t' - t'') = 2Dt \quad (4.5)$$

which is the same result we would find from other methods in considering a random walk. To find the response function we can notice that

$$-w\omega\tilde{x} = \mu\tilde{F} \quad (4.6)$$

therefore

$$\tilde{\chi}(\omega) = \frac{i\mu}{\omega} \implies \tilde{\chi}'' = \frac{\mu}{\omega} \quad (4.7)$$

If we compare this to the correlation function

$$C_v(t) = \langle v_B(t)v_B(0) \rangle = 2D\delta(t) \implies \tilde{C}_v = 2D \quad (4.8)$$

and

$$v = \dot{x} \implies \tilde{v} = i\omega\tilde{x} \implies \tilde{C}_v(\omega) = \omega^2\tilde{C}_x(\omega) \quad (4.9)$$

and therefore

$$\boxed{\tilde{C}_x(\omega) = \frac{2D}{\omega^2}} \quad (4.10)$$

and now applying the FDT

$$\frac{2D}{\omega^2} = \frac{2k_B T}{\omega} \tilde{\chi}''(\omega) = 2k_B T \frac{\mu}{\omega^2} \quad (4.11)$$

implies

$$\boxed{D = k_B T \mu} \quad (4.12)$$

This concludes the introduction prior to discussing active matter.

3 Hydrodynamic Theory Of Polar Active Matter

3.1 Hydrodynamic Theory And Slow Variables

The hydrodynamic theory is a continuum theory made to describe the changes in fields over large time scales and large distances. Such a theory can be developed in two main ways:

Start From a Microscopic Model and perform coarse-graining.

Directly Write Macroscopic equations based on conservation laws and symmetries.

We will focus on the 2nd approach. Later in the course we will present a standardized method to develop such a theory from considerations of entropy production.

Slow Variables

We'll assume a set of fast variables $\{\psi_k\}$ and slow variables $\{\varphi_i\}$ which satisfy equations of the form

$$\frac{\partial \psi_k}{\partial t} = \frac{1}{\tau_f} G_k(\{\psi_j\}, \{\varphi_j\}) \quad (4.13)$$

$$\frac{\partial \varphi_i}{\partial t} = \frac{1}{\tau_s} F_i(\{\psi_j\}, \{\varphi_j\}) \quad (4.14)$$

where τ_s and τ_f are time constants which satisfy

$$\tau_f = O(1) \quad \tau_s = O(L^\alpha) \quad (4.15)$$

with $\alpha > 0$ and L the size of the system. For large systems we'll find separation on time scales. For large systems we'll write

$$G_k(\{\psi_j\}, \{\varphi_j\}) = 0 \quad (4.16)$$

and we'll express the fast variables in terms of the slow variables. Explicitly, we'll normalize times using τ_s such that

$$\tilde{t} = \frac{t}{\tau_s} \quad (4.17)$$

and we'll find

$$\frac{\partial \psi_k}{\partial \tilde{t}} = \frac{\tau_s}{\tau_f} G_k(\dots) \quad (4.18)$$

$$\frac{\partial \varphi_i}{\partial \tilde{t}} = F_i(\dots) \quad (4.19)$$

and since

$$\frac{\tau_s}{\tau_f} = O(L^\alpha) \gg 1 \quad (4.20)$$

we'll find that to leading order

$$G_k = 0 \quad (4.21)$$

next we express $\{\psi_k\}$ in terms of $\{\varphi_i\}$ and find

$$\frac{\partial \varphi_i}{\partial \tilde{t}} = \frac{1}{\tau_s} \bar{F}(\{\varphi_j\}) + \xi_i(t) \quad (4.22)$$

where

$$\bar{F}(\{\varphi_j\}) = F(\{\varphi_j\}, \{\psi_k(\{\varphi_j\})\}) \quad (4.23)$$

The influence of the fast variables comes into effect through the noise function ξ_i which has $\langle \xi_i \rangle = 0$. For short correlation times it is customary to assume

$$\langle \xi_i(t) \xi_j(t') \rangle \propto \delta_{ij} \delta(t - t') \quad (4.24)$$

in this course we'll focus on an average description without the noise. Otherwise the theory is called Fluctuating Hydrodynamics.

Types Of Slow Variables

Conserved Quantities They satisfy a continuum equation

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot j \quad (4.25)$$

without a spatial change in φ there is no current therefore

$$j = -\alpha \nabla \varphi \quad (4.26)$$

we can insert this and find

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t} = \alpha \nabla^2 \varphi + \dots \quad (4.27)$$

we'll perform a fourier transform

$$\tilde{\varphi}_{\mathbf{q}} = \int d\mathbf{r} e^{-i\mathbf{q} \cdot \mathbf{r}} \varphi(\mathbf{r}) \quad (4.28)$$

therefore

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\varphi}_{\mathbf{q}}}{\partial t} = -\alpha q^2 \tilde{\varphi}_{\mathbf{q}} + \dots \quad (4.29)$$

in conclusion, the time to decay to mode $\mathbf{q}$ is

$$\tau_{\mathbf{q}} \sim q^{-2} \quad (4.30)$$

The hydrodynamic theory focuses on large length scales (small q -s). The smallest q is $\frac{\pi}{L}$, therefore $\tau \sim L^2$. In a more general case, the dynamics of a conserved quantity is described by Model B

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot j \quad (4.31)$$

$$j = -\gamma \nabla \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} + \xi \quad (4.32)$$

$$F[\varphi] = \int d\mathbf{r} f(\varphi, \nabla \varphi) \quad (4.33)$$

where F is the free energy functional, γ is a kinetic parameter, and ξ is noise which satisfies

$$\langle \xi_i \rangle = 0 \quad (4.34)$$

and

$$\langle \xi_i(t) \xi_j(t') \rangle = 2k_B T \gamma \delta_{ij} \delta(t - t') \quad (4.35)$$

and we'll notice that

$$\dot{F} = \int \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \dot{\varphi} d\mathbf{r} = \gamma \int \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \partial_\alpha \partial_\alpha \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} d\mathbf{r} \quad (4.36)$$

$$= -\gamma \int \left(\partial_\alpha \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \right) \left(\partial_\alpha \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \right) < 0, \quad \gamma > 0 \quad (4.37)$$

in a classical hydrodynamic theory (NS) the conserved quantities are the mass and momentum.

Soft/Goldstone Mode When a free energy is invariant w.r.t a continuous quantity, that quantity is called a soft mode. We mentioned this when we discussed the MW theorem when we looked at the mode x (magnetization with continuous angle). We'll look at two configurations which have a different structure but the same free energy. both have the same free energy, therefore there is no reason for one to decay into the other. The typical time to decay will be proportional to the size of the system. The dynamics of such quantities which aren't conserved are described by Model A

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t} = -\gamma \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} + \xi \quad (4.38)$$

where

$$\dot{F} = \int \frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t} \, d\mathbf{r} = -\gamma \int \left(\frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} \right)^2 \, d\mathbf{r} < 0, \quad \gamma > 0 \quad (4.39)$$

so

$$F = \int d\mathbf{r} \left(\frac{1}{2} K (\nabla \varphi)^2 + \dots \right) \quad (4.40)$$

where

$$\frac{\delta F}{\delta \varphi} = -k \nabla^2 \varphi \quad (4.41)$$

and again we find a diffusion equation with $\tau \sim L^2$.

Lecture 5.

Wed, December 3rd, 2025

Order Parameter Near Critical Points (Type 2 Transition)

If we look at the Ginzburg-Landau free energy

$$F = \int d\mathbf{r} \left(\frac{a}{2} \varphi^2 + \frac{b}{4} \varphi^4 + \frac{K}{2} (\nabla \varphi)^2 \right) \quad (5.1)$$

near the critical point ($a = 0$) $\varphi = 0$ and the free energy almost does not change with φ , similarly to the soft mode. The slowing down of the dynamics near a critical point is called *critical slowing down*.

4 Hydrodynamic Theory For Polar Active Matter On a Surface (Toner Tu, 1995)

As a reminder, a polarization field is

$$\mathbf{P} = \langle \mathbf{n} \rangle \quad (5.2)$$

what are the slow parameters?

Mass / Number of Particles are a conserved quantity

Momentum? NO! Since we're interacting with a surface there is friction, thus momentum is not conserved.

The direction $\frac{\mathbf{P}}{|\mathbf{P}|}$ is a soft mode.

$|\mathbf{P}|$ is a slow parameter near the critical points if P changes continuously in phase transition.

We'll write equations for ρ and $\mathbf{P}$ as if they were passive and add phenomenology of active elements. Active matter on a surface is called "dry". Later in the course we'll deal with "wet" active matter too in which the particles are in a liquid medium and there is conservation of momentum.

4.1 Equations for Density

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot \mathbf{j} \quad \mathbf{j} = -\gamma_\rho \nabla \frac{\delta F}{\delta \rho} + \rho v_0 \mathbf{P} \quad \gamma_\rho > 0 \quad (5.3)$$

where $\frac{\delta F}{\delta \rho}$ is the chemical potential and $\rho v_0 \mathbf{P}$ is the active current element which is equivalent to assuming speed $v\hat{n}$ for each particle in the absence of gradients. How did we define this element? We need to find a vector, and the only vectors in the system are $\mathbf{P}$ and ∇ . In the hydrodynamic limit $\nabla \sim L^{-1}$ and is small in comparison to $\mathbf{P}$. In addition, many gradient element can be found from the passive element.

4.2 Equation for Polarization

$$\frac{\partial \mathbf{P}}{\partial t} + \lambda_1 (\mathbf{P} \cdot \nabla) \mathbf{P} = -\gamma_P \frac{\delta F}{\delta \mathbf{P}} \quad (5.4)$$

where $\lambda_1 (\mathbf{P} \cdot \nabla) \mathbf{P}$ is an element added which is similar to the advection element in Navier-Stokes ($\frac{d}{dt} \mathbf{u}(t, \mathbf{x}) = \partial_t \mathbf{u} + (\mathbf{v} \cdot \nabla) \mathbf{u}$). In an active system $\mathbf{P}$ plays a double role of both an order parameter and of the velocity such that its equation is similar to NS. Why didn't we choose other elements? Elements without derivatives can be found from $\frac{\delta F}{\delta \mathbf{P}}$. Other elements with first order derivatives we can also find from F. λ_1 is a phenomenological element and doesn't necessarily satisfy $\lambda_1 = v_0$ like in NS. This is because there is no conservation of momentum or Galileo invariance.

4.3 Isotropic-Polar Transition (Flocking Transition)

If we look at a homogenous system, the equation for $\mathbf{P}$ is equivalent to a passive system. The isotropic-polar transition will be determined by the form of the free energy. We'll write down free energy like in Landau theory where the density is the critical parameter:

$$F = \int d\mathbf{r} \left(\frac{a}{2} \left(1 - \frac{\rho}{\rho_c} \right) P^2 + \frac{b}{4} P^4 + \dots \right) \quad b > 0 \quad (5.5)$$

for $\rho < \rho_c$ a minimum F at $P = 0$ and the system is isotropic.

for $\rho \geq \rho_c$ we'll find a minimum $P_0 = \sqrt{\frac{-a}{b}}$ and then the system is polar.

In a more general manner the transition can be described depending on the density and the effective temperature T . In hydrodynamic theory, F will include a contribution from an ordering interaction like in the XY model, in which case $1/T$ acts as the strength of the interaction. In the Vicsek model, T is tied to the strength of the noise in determining the direction of the particles.

4.4 What's Special About the Active System?

Coexistence has special dynamics of traveling bands. Additionally, the stability of the polar phase is different to that of a passive system. In particular, in contradiction of the MW theorem there can be long range order which breaks continuous symmetry in 2D. How is this possible? First, this is a system out of equilibrium, so the theorem doesn't apply. In as simple terms as possible, we'll explain how the polar phase is stable thanks to the active advection element $(\lambda_1 (\mathbf{P} \cdot \nabla) \mathbf{P})$.

We'll analyze the instability in a passive system in a new way. We'll assume an ordered system with $\theta = 0$ and a point deviation at $\mathbf{r} = 0$ to the angle $\delta\theta$. Since it's a soft mode, the deviation decays diffusively ($\partial_t \delta\theta \sim \nabla^2 \delta\theta$). In d dimensions at time τ , the deviation is "smeared" over the volume $V_e \sim \tau^{d/2}$. Deviations are constantly created, so at time τ there are

$$n_e \sim V_e \cdot \tau \sim \tau^{1+d/2} \quad (5.6)$$

deviations in the volume. The deviations are in random directions. From the central limit theorem, the standard deviation satisfies

$$\Omega_e \sim \sqrt{n_e} \sim \sqrt{\tau V_e} \quad (5.7)$$

and the average deviation per particle is

$$\Delta\theta \sim \frac{\Omega_e}{V_e} \sim \sqrt{\frac{\tau}{V_e}} \sim r^{1-d/2} \quad (5.8)$$

where $\tau \sim \sqrt{r}$, and in the thermodynamic limit r is large. We found $\Delta\theta$ is insignificant for $d > 2$, and grows with the system's size for $d < 2$. The case $d = 2$ is marginal and gives $\Delta\theta \sim l_n L$. This is similar to the calculation at equilibrium. It is important that the order is continuous because noise causes small fluctuations, in contrast to domain wall energy.

Lecture 6.

Wed, December 10th, 2025

In the active case, the volume V_{int} is determined not only by diffusion but also by advection. A deviation $\delta\theta$ creates different separation between particles in the $\hat{n} \parallel \hat{p}$ direction and the $\hat{n} \perp \hat{p}$ direction. This gives us

$$\hat{P} = (\cos \theta, \sin \theta) \approx \left(1 - \frac{1}{2}\delta\theta^2, \delta\theta\right) \quad (6.1)$$

and

$$\delta x_{\perp} \sim v_0 \tau \sin \delta\theta \sim \tau \delta\theta \quad \delta x_{\parallel} \sim v_0 \tau \delta\theta^2 \sim \tau \delta\theta^2 \quad (6.2)$$

and the volume

$$V_e \sim \omega_{\perp}^{d-1} \omega_{\parallel} \quad (6.3)$$

From a combination of advection and diffusion:

$$\omega_{\perp} \sim \delta x_{\perp} + D_{\perp} \tau^{1/2} \sim \tau \delta\theta + D_{\perp} \tau^{1/2} \sim \tau^{\gamma_{\perp}} \quad (6.4)$$

and

$$\omega_{\parallel} \sim \delta x_{\parallel} + D_{\parallel} \tau^{1/2} \sim \tau \delta\theta^2 + D_{\parallel} \tau^{1/2} \sim \tau^{\gamma} \quad (6.5)$$

if we define $\delta\theta \sim \tau^{\gamma}$ then we also find

$$\delta\theta \sim \sqrt{\frac{\tau}{V_e}} \sim \frac{\tau^{1/2}}{\sqrt{\omega_{\perp}^{d-1} \omega_{\parallel}}} \sim \tau^{\gamma} \quad (6.6)$$

We thus have to solve three equations for the gammas:

$$2\gamma = 1 - \gamma_{\parallel} - (d-1)\gamma_{\perp} \quad (6.7)$$

$$\gamma_{\perp} = \max\left(1 + \gamma, \frac{1}{2}\right) \quad (6.8)$$

$$\gamma_{\parallel} = \max\left(1 + 2\gamma, \frac{1}{2}\right) \quad (6.9)$$

we find $\gamma < 0$ for all $d > 1$. Specifically for $d = 2$ we find

$$\gamma = -\frac{1}{5} \quad \gamma_{\perp} = \frac{4}{5} \quad \gamma_{\parallel} = \frac{3}{5} \quad (6.10)$$

This means the order is stable, thanks to the ‘quick smearing’ in the direction perpendicular to $\mathbf{P}$. A couple of notes:

- The stability of polar phase is still being researched in a more rigorous manner.
- Current research shows that active polar order has additional properties. For example, a boundary effect can affect order in bulk (Yariv Kafri).

4.5 Waves in Active Polar Matter

Remembering the equations

$$\frac{\partial P}{\partial t} = -\partial_{\alpha} j_{\alpha} \quad j_{\alpha} = -\gamma_{\rho} \partial_{\alpha} \frac{\delta F}{\delta \rho} + v_0 \rho P_{\alpha} \quad \frac{\partial P_{\alpha}}{\partial t} + \lambda (P_{\beta} \partial_{\beta}) = -\gamma_P \frac{\delta F}{\delta P_{\alpha}} \quad (6.11)$$

We’ll examine small deviations around the homogenous stable state

$$\rho = \rho_0 + \delta\rho(t, \mathbf{r}) \quad \mathbf{P} = \mathbf{P}_0 + \delta\mathbf{P}(t, \mathbf{r}) \quad (6.12)$$

for

$$\frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0}, \frac{|\mathbf{P}|}{|\mathbf{P}|} \ll 1 \quad (6.13)$$

we'll linearize the equations and keep leading elements in the derivatives (first order). For simplicity we'll assume $\mathbf{P} = \hat{x} + \delta P \hat{y} \implies$ the steady state is completely ordered and only rotations of the polarizations are possible. In this case, there is a steady current $\mathbf{j}_0 = \rho_0 v_0 \hat{x}$. In this case we won't interest ourselves with the Landau elements of the free energy ($\frac{a}{2}P^2 + \frac{b}{4}P^4$).

$$F = \int d^2r \left[\frac{\chi}{2} \left(\frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0} \right)^2 + \frac{1}{2} k \partial_\alpha P_\beta \partial_\alpha P_\beta + \left(\omega_0 - \omega_1 \frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0} \right) \partial_\alpha P_\alpha \right] \quad (6.14)$$

What does the last element mean? From integration by parts

$$F = \int d^2r \left[\dots - P_\alpha \partial_\alpha \left(\omega_0 - \omega_1 \frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0} \right) \right] + \text{boundary element} \quad (6.15)$$

$$= \int d^2r \left[\dots + \frac{\omega_1}{\rho} \mathbf{P} \cdot \nabla \rho \right] \quad (6.16)$$

ω_0 only contributes a boundary element. ω_1 determines whether $\mathbf{P}$ likes to order itself with or against the gradients in the density. We'll develop the equation in 6.11 to first order in $\delta\rho, \delta P$ and up to derivatives of first order and find

$$\partial_t \delta\rho = -\partial_\alpha (v_0 \delta\rho P_\alpha^0 + v_0 \rho_0 \delta P_\alpha) \quad (6.17)$$

where

$$(\partial_t + v_0 \partial_x) \delta\rho \approx -v_0 \rho_0 \partial_y \delta P \quad (6.18)$$

$$(\partial_t + \lambda \partial_x) \delta P \approx -\gamma_P \omega_1 \partial_y \frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0} \quad (6.19)$$

because

$$\frac{\delta F}{\delta P_\alpha} = -k \partial_\beta \delta P_\alpha + \frac{\omega_1}{\rho_0} \partial_\alpha \delta\rho \quad (6.20)$$

If the system is homogenous in the y direction, we find that $\delta P, \delta\rho$ are independent up to first order. One moves at velocity v_0 and the other at velocity λ . If the system is homogenous in the x direction, we find

$$\partial_t \delta\rho = -v_0 \rho_0 \partial_y \delta P \quad (6.21)$$

$$\partial_t \delta P = -\gamma_P \omega_1 \partial_y \frac{\delta\rho}{\rho_0} \quad (6.22)$$

which gives us

$$\partial_{tt} \delta\rho = v_0 \gamma_P \omega_1 \partial_{yy} \delta\rho \quad (6.23)$$

for $\omega_1 > 0$ we found a wave equation with the velocity

$$c = \sqrt{\omega_1 \gamma_P v_0} \quad (6.24)$$

Changes in the density reorganize $\mathbf{P}$ and changes in $\mathbf{P}$ transport the density because of the activity. Note: the higher order terms in derivatives will lead to decay of the waves, i.e to diffusion.

5 Nematic Active Matter

5.1 The Nematic Order Parameter

So far we dealt with polar order $\mathbf{P} = \langle \hat{l} \rangle$ with a distinct direction. Sometimes there is only a distinct axis. This kind of order is called nematic. The order parameter is the Nematic Tensor:

$$Q_{\alpha\beta} = \left\langle \hat{l}_\alpha \hat{l}_\beta - \frac{\delta_{\alpha\beta}}{d} \right\rangle = Q \left(n_\alpha n_\beta - \frac{\delta_{\alpha\beta}}{d} \right) \quad (6.25)$$

Its properties are

1. Invariant to the substitution $\hat{n} \iff -\hat{n}$
2. It is symmetric and traceless

For $d = 2$ and complete order along the $\hat{x}$ axis:

$$Q_{\alpha\beta} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{1}{2} & 0 \\ 0 & -\frac{1}{2} \end{pmatrix} \quad (6.26)$$

in general, in the direction $\theta \rightarrow \hat{n} = (\cos \theta, \sin \theta)$

$$Q_{\alpha\beta} = \frac{1}{2} \begin{pmatrix} \cos(2\theta) & \sin(2\theta) \\ \sin(2\theta) & -\cos(2\theta) \end{pmatrix} \quad (6.27)$$

with the angle being 2θ representing the fact that $\hat{n} \iff -\hat{n}$ ($\theta \iff \theta + \pi$). A physical theory of nematic matter can be also written in terms of $\hat{n}$ while maintaining the symmetry for $\hat{n} \iff -\hat{n}$ and a scalar parameter Q . In practice, it is customary to sometimes use $\mathbf{P}$ instead of $\hat{n}$. Remember this does not mean there is a preferred direction. Even if we can write $\langle \hat{l}_\alpha \rangle$ we can write

$$Q_{\alpha\beta} = P_\alpha P_\beta - P_\mu P_\mu \frac{\delta_{\alpha\beta}}{d} \quad (6.28)$$

and in nematic theory the symmetry $\mathbf{P} \iff -\mathbf{P}$ must be maintained. What does that mean? Let's return to the equations.

$$F = \int d\mathbf{r} \left[\frac{a}{2} P^2 + \frac{b}{4} P^4 + \frac{K}{2} \partial_\alpha P_\beta \partial_\alpha P_\beta - \omega(\rho) \partial_\alpha \overline{P_\alpha} + \dots \right] \quad (6.29)$$

The final element does not fit the symmetry we require so we cannot use it in nematic theory.

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} = -\partial_\alpha j_\alpha \quad j_\alpha = -\gamma_\rho \partial_\alpha \frac{\delta F}{\delta \rho} + v_\theta \rho \overline{P_\alpha} \quad (6.30)$$

the final element in the right hand equation also cannot be used for the same reason. Finally

$$\frac{\partial P_\alpha}{\partial t} + \lambda \overline{(P_\mu \partial_\mu) P_\alpha} = -\gamma_P \rho \frac{\delta F}{\delta P_\alpha} \quad (6.31)$$

The unintuitively cancelled element is $(\mathbf{P} \cdot \nabla) \mathbf{P}$. Why is it unallowed? Intuitively it comes from advection which no longer exists. Mathematically, we'll multiply by P_β and find

$$P_\beta \partial_t P_\alpha + \lambda P_\beta (P_\mu \partial_\mu) P_\alpha = \dots \quad (6.32)$$

$$\partial_t Q_{\alpha\beta} + \lambda \overline{(P_\mu \partial_\mu) Q_{\alpha\beta}} = \dots \quad (6.33)$$

What is the active contribution? We need to take into consideration active currents. How can we build it from $Q_{\alpha\beta}$? We need to apply a vector on it. Without a defined direction, the only vector is ∇ :

$$J = -\gamma_\rho \nabla \frac{\delta F}{\delta \rho} - \Lambda \nabla \cdot \mathbf{Q} \quad (6.34)$$

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